

Ancestors West



SANTA BARBARA COUNTY GENEALOGICAL SOCIETY

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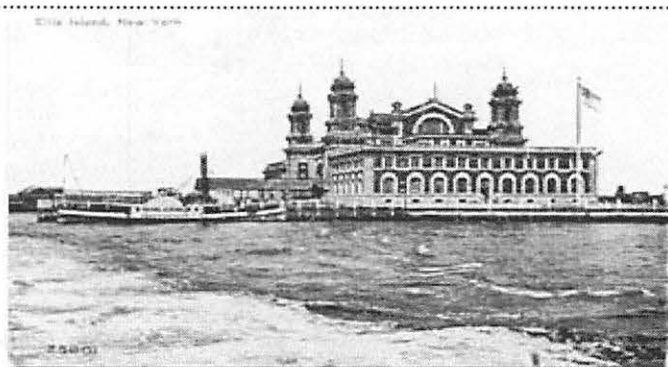
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ELLIS ISLAND: THE DREAM OF
AMERICA
IS COMING TO
SANTA BARBARA IN APRIL
(SEE PAGE 24 AND BACK COVER)



GOOD GRIEF, CHARLEY BROWN!

By Richard H. Dittman, SBCGS Member
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There are many reasons for settling in Santa Barbara: climate, hunting, family, business, and culture. But how about fleeing the long arm of the law? During the 1840s Santa Barbara was about as far away from the *Polizei* in Berlin as a fugitive could possibly be.

Carl August Dittmann was born on the 7th of November 1825 in Berlin, Kingdom of Prussia. He was the third of seven children born to Wilhelm Dittmann and Johanne Öhlbrecht. Carl told his children that at age fourteen he became an apprentice in a furniture factory. There he received a beating from his employer for making a mistake while caning a chair. Learning of his son's beating, Wilhelm argued with the employer. A scuffle ensued and both father and son were thrown in jail; an apprentice was given few rights in Berlin at that time. Carl decided to run away. When informed of his son's decision, Wilhelm said, "I don't blame you. I wish I could too."

According to his *Narrative*,¹ Carl traveled north about eighty miles to the small seaport of Ueckermünde. He eluded the police, who must have been looking for him, because he broke his contract. Then as a cook's boy he sailed away in Captain Rathmann's ship.

In February 1842, after having risen to the rank of able-bodied seaman, Carl sailed from Liverpool to Quebec and back. He writes in his *Narrative*, "The weather was very cold . . . being almost constantly wet . . . I suffered very much . . . [I] determined to make no more voyages to cold climates." Although being a fugitive from the law caused Carl to leave home, he now had the incentive to search for a warm climate.

His next voyage was a round-trip to the sunny West Indies, which was completed without incident. On the following trip, Carl sailed from Liverpool to Valparaíso, Chile aboard the English brig *Euphemia*.

This decision was pivotal for two reasons. First, Carl would eventually arrive in Santa Barbara, and second, he took on an alias. While signing on, the skipper Captain John Nightingale seemed to have had trouble spelling Carl Dittmann, as the story goes. So in exasperation Nightingale said, "Aw hell, you're Charley Brown!" Records show that a "real" Charley Brown had sailed on a previous voyage; perhaps Captain Nightingale was too lazy to change his records.

A source of confusion for historians of pre-pioneer California is that another Charles Brown, born in New York, deserted the whaling ship *Helvetius* in San Francisco in 1833.² He settled in northern California and died in Sonoma in 1883.

The voyage from Liverpool to Valparaíso began on January 19, 1843. Nowhere in his *Narrative* does Carl write about any difficulty sailing around Cape Horn, the often-

stormy southern tip of South America. Indeed, Carl later told his family that the sea was calm. Carl's experience was unlike that of Richard Dana, who endured days of sleet and snow as he sailed around Cape Horn in 1834 and 1836.³

Carl writes, "At Valparaíso . . . instead of going back to Liverpool, we started for California. Our vessel was chartered by Captains John Wilson and James Scott, of Upper California. She was loaded with an assorted cargo and was to call at many ports on the California coast."

From Valparaíso they sailed to Callao, Peru and thence to Honolulu, arriving on December 13, 1843. The trip so far had been a total 328 days, of which it is estimated that 258 days were at sea and the remaining 70 anchored in a port.

Because the *Euphemia* was judged by the British Admiralty in Honolulu to be unseaworthy and condemned, the cargo was transferred to the brigantine *Juanita* in January 1844. Charley Brown signed on again with Wilson and Scott to sail for Monterey, where taxes were levied by the Mexican government on cargo imported to Upper California.

"From Monterey . . . we came direct to Santa Barbara, arriving here in [spring] 1844." Carl Dittmann, alias Charley Brown, may have been the first native of present-day Germany to become a permanent settler in Santa Barbara.

In Santa Barbara Charley was put in charge of Captain Scott's storehouse, which is described in his *Narrative* as "the old adobe building, that one still standing [1878] just below Cook's building and a little off State Street."

Something of Charley's character is revealed in the next lines of his *Narrative*. "Here I remained all the summer of 1844 in charge of the store house . . . The boatswain was discharged here and again tried to influence Capt. Scott against me by false reports. This time I gave him a good clubbing, very near breaking his arm."

In April 1845 Charley gave up storekeeping and began the very lucrative activity of otter hunting with Isaac Sparks, George Nidever, and James Breck. Fifteen years later Charley was still reporting his occupation as otter hunter on the 1860 Census.

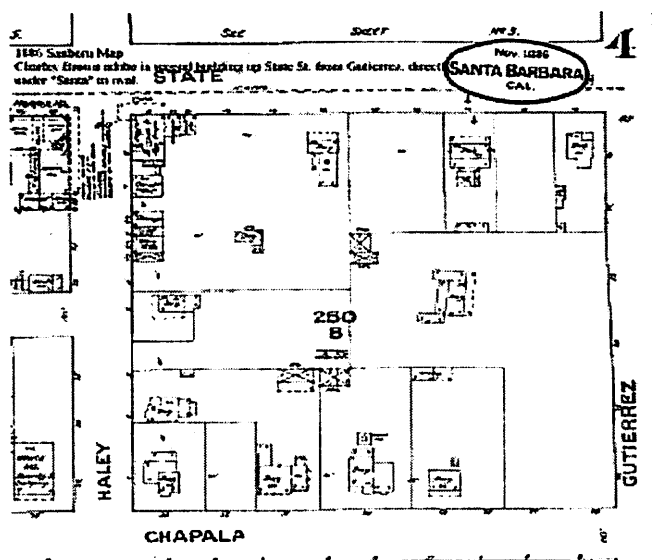
In July 1846 the hunters stopped at Monterey to find the American navy in possession of the port. There Charley learned of the war with Mexico. After hunting farther north the hunters returned to a camp just above the harbor of San Luis Obispo, where they were warned about a band of marauders. Late that night they slipped away from their camp out to sea and safety. "There were several of them headed by an Italian called Antonio, a regular desperado, who was killed two or three days afterwards. . . . (members of the band) acknowledged that they intended to kill us all and take our skins."

Upon arriving at Santa Barbara, they were arrested by Californians (Mexican citizens). Bill Fife (a Scot) and Charley Brown (a German) were released, while the Americans were held. Charley declined to join either side in the war and continued his otter hunting.

When gold was discovered at Coloma in January 1848, Charley interrupted his otter hunting. He could not get away in 1848, but in March 1849 he went to the Stanislaus

diggings (north of Sonora) with George Islip and Julian Foxen to seek his fortune. After two months of mining, Charley returned to Santa Barbara with \$1,030 in gold. In the spring of 1850 he returned to the same diggings and mined only \$500 in gold after four months. He then quit mining and resumed otter hunting in Santa Barbara.

Charley became a homeowner in Santa Barbara during August 1850, when for \$310 he bought "Casa de Olive," located on the southwestern side of State Street between Haley Street and Gutierrez Street. The property was purchased from the estate of James Scott, the merchant whose warehouse Charley had occupied in 1844.⁴ Charley lived there until August 1887, when he sold his holdings and moved to Lompoc.



1886 SANBORN MAP

CHARLEY BROWN'S ADOBE IS THE SECOND BUILDING UP STATE ST. FROM GUTIERREZ, DIRECTLY UNDER "SANTA" IN THE OVAL.
MAP FURNISHED BY JOHN WOODWARD, SBCGS MEMBER

[Note from John Woodward: Casa de Olive was probably built after streets were laid out in the 1851 Haley survey since it is parallel to State Street (compare to Maria Cordero adobe at angle behind Brown adobe in right center of block). Original map with color coding shows central part of main house and cook house immediately in rear as being made of adobe.]

Charley Brown's *Narrative* ends in the summer 1853 with a long description of finding the lone Indian woman of San Nicholas Island. Curiously, Charley never related anything about his family.

Those years around 1850 were especially important because of Brown's marriage to Francisca Cascareña and births of their son Carlos and daughter Maria Juana. Family life was the last and most important reason for Charley Brown to settle in Santa Barbara.

No record has been found at Our Lady of Sorrows Church for the marriage of Charley Brown and Francisca Cascareña. That is not surprising, since he was Lutheran and she was

Catholic. The 1850 Census has an entry for only Charles Brown, age 25, of Prussia. His wife Francisca's name does not appear, but there is a check mark for the column listing "Married within the last year." Her name has not been found anywhere in California in the 1850 Census.

The only record at Our Lady of Sorrows Church for any Brown is a baptism for "Maria Juana Brown on November 5, 1850, daughter of Carlos Brown and an Indian neophyte of San Luis Rey named Francisca."⁵ The birth date is given as October 31. Because the enumeration date on the 1850 Census for the page listing Charles Brown is October 29, perhaps Francisca was giving birth to Maria Juana somewhere in seclusion. This might be the reason that she was entirely missed on that census.

There is much less information on their son Carlos (Charles, Jr.). On the 1860 Census for Santa Barbara, taken on June 7, 1860, one finds four members of the Charles Brown family. Charles (Sr.) is listed as an otter hunter, born in Prussia, and the other family members are born in California. Francisca's age is given as 30. Juana's age is given as 12, suggesting that she was born in 1847 (contrary to her baptismal record!), and a boy, Charles, age 10 years, suggesting that he was born in 1849 or 1850. The children's ages don't add up! But census records are often not accurate, and so far, they are the only official documents showing that the son Charles ever lived.

A most significant document appears in the *Actions of the Santa Barbara District Court* on April 11, 1861. The abridged transcript reads, "I, Charles Dittmann, commonly known as Charles Brown which latter name I hereby declare is not my true name . . . acknowledge myself to be the father of Charles Cascareña aged about twelve years, and Juana Cascareña aged about eleven years . . . of an Indian woman . . . Francisca Cascareña, formerly of the mission of San Luis Rey, and I . . . hereby adopt . . . [them] . . . as my own children."

In this document that acknowledged the name Brown to be an alias, Charles also changed his children's surname Cascareña (not Brown) to Dittmann. Notice that the children's surname had been that of their mother. It seems that he was adopting his own children, perhaps because he was never married to Francisca and she may have died. This document is probably more accurate than the 1860 Census concerning the children's birth order and ages. Charles was born probably in 1849 and Juana definitely in September 1850.

Another clue that Francisca may have died during the latter half of 1860 appears in the article, "St. Vincent's Students."⁶ Jane Dittman (formerly known as Maria Juana Brown or Juana Cascareña) appears once, in the 1861 school year for St. Vincent's school and orphan asylum for girls. The Daughters of Charity of St. Vincent de Paul also accepted "half-orphans," described as having one deceased parent.

The next significant record is the Letter of Intent (for naturalization) that Charles Dittman (as he then spelled his

surname), alias Chas. Brown, signed on July 20, 1867 in the Court of the First Judicial District in Santa Barbara. He finalized his naturalization on July 31, 1871.

There is no mention of Charles Dittman Jr. during the 1860s. The last official record of him is the 1870 Census for Santa Barbara. That census, on the page enumerated August 12, 1870, lists Charles Ditman, age 46, carpenter from Prussia; [no Francisca!]; Charles Ditman, age 21; Jane Ditman, age 19. Jane's age is consistent with her baptismal records. So it seems likely that her brother Charles was born before August 1849, probably June or July. A few months earlier Charley was finding gold left and right, then left after only two months. Perhaps he gave up mining in order to hurry home to his pregnant wife.

While browsing through court records, I discovered a document that greatly complicated Charley Brown's life.

In court proceedings⁷ that were recorded on August 10, 1852, Francisca was the plaintiff in a child custody case. "... a Writ of Habeas Corpus by Francisca Cascareña setting forth that her minor child named Refugio was unlawfully restrained ... by Jose Carrillo. ... The Court ordered that the body of the child Refugio be delivered up to the custody and possession of her mother Francisca Cascareña ..."

This document prompts many questions. Who is the father of Refugio and when was she born? (She was not identified as Charley Brown's child when he claimed Charles and Juana in 1861, so Jose Carrillo probably fathered her before 1849.) Whatever happened to Refugio? (No trace of Refugio Carrillo was found in either the 1850 or 1860 Census.) Did Charley save Francisca from an abusive relationship or was she a "wanton woman," as they liked to say in the nineteenth century? Good grief, Charley Brown! Well, back to the story of his two children born of Francisca Cascareña.

Mary Jane Dittman, as she preferred to be called as an adult, was married on May 1, 1872 to Benjamin W.C. Brown. Isn't that confusing! Mary Jane's birth surname and married surname are both Brown. Benjamin was born in Newport, Rhode Island on January 5, 1833. He came to Santa Barbara as a sailor and held various jobs, including being a deputy to Sheriff Don Nicolas Covarrubias about 1878 and a saloonkeeper in 1880.

In May 1873 Charles Dittman gave his daughter Mary Jane Brown "in consideration of love and affection" a belated wedding gift, all the real property on the northwest side of Gutierrez Street between State Street and Anacapa Street. In other words, Mary's property was half a block away from her childhood home.

A marriage license records that Charles Dittman married Margaret Wetfield (actually, Whitfield) in Santa Barbara on October 11, 1873 with Rev. James Vila presiding. Margaret was an Irish immigrant from Australia who worked as a seamstress for Dr. James Shaw. She had been attracted to the beautiful garden planted by Charles. Theirs was a "May-and-December" marriage; she was age 25 and he was age 52. They had five children before moving away from Santa

Barbara in 1887, but that is another story.

Mrs. Mary Brown was a part of her father's second family, being godmother to her half-brothers Thomas Dittman and Ludwig Dittman. Another half-brother, also named Charles, remembers an argument between Mary and Margaret about the disposition of some furniture after the house on State Street was sold. Not until the late 1950s did the Dittman boys learn from Ludwig's son Henry that Mary was their half-sister.

On July 9, 1883 Benjamin Brown died, apparently leaving no children. Mary Brown lived on at 115 Gutierrez Street for the rest of her life. She can be found at that residence on every census from 1880 to 1920, except of course, 1890.

Mary Brown later became a source of information about Santa Barbara during the 1850s and 1860s. An extensive interview of her appears in the May 13, 1922 issue of *The Daily News* published in Santa Barbara, wherein she relates that the family home on State Street "stood on the site of what is now Faith Mission, next to Jones Cafeteria." In that same interview she tells that her brother, Charles Dittman, had been an otter hunter. Later he became a sailor and was lost at sea in 1894 when his ship sank.

Elsewhere Mary goes into more detail⁸ about her brother. She relates that he "was hunting with Capt. George Nidever and his son, young George, in the waters of Lower California, in 1865." During that hunt he shot an otter and gave the skin to Mary. She had possession of it in 1922, when it was valued at \$7,000. She died on June 9, 1929 and was buried at Calvary Cemetery.

The author wishes to acknowledge the assistance of Kathleen Brewster and Dorothy Oksner, as well as apologies to Charles Schultz.

Endnotes:

1. Carl Dittmann, *Narrative of a Seafaring Life on the Coast of California*, Bancroft Library, Berkeley, California, 1878. A copy can be found at Gledhill Library of the Santa Barbara Historical Society.
2. *The Works of Hubert Howe Bancroft*, A.L. Bancroft & Company, San Francisco, 1885, Vol. XIX, pp. 731-732.
3. R.H. Dana, Jr., *Two Years Before the Mast*, P.F. Collier & Son, New York, 1909, pp. 34-36 and 298-308.
4. Book of Deeds, Santa Barbara County, Vol. B, 1851-1857, pp. 1-4. Microfilm #1451275, Item #4, Family History Library [FHL] Salt Lake City, Utah.
5. Our Lady of Sorrows Church, *Record of Baptisms*, Vol. 2, #326.
6. *St. Vincent's Students*, Ancestors West, SBCGS, Vol. 29, No. 4 (Summer 2003), pp. 8-9.
7. *District Court Minutes, Santa Barbara County*, Vol. A, pp. 22-23.
8. Michael James Phillips, *History of Santa Barbara, California*, S.J. Clarke Publishing Company, Chicago, 1927, pp. 111-112.